HELEN BOKEA

Global Health Leadership & Governance | Health Systems Strengthening | Implementation Strategy Consulting
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I am a visionary and results-driven global health leader with nearly two decades of experience leading large-scale, transformative health programmes across Africa, Asia, and Latin America. I have held senior leadership and consultancy roles with prominent global organizations, including CBM International, the Foundation for Innovative New Diagnostics (FIND), Rice University's Institute of Global Health Technologies (NEST360 Initiative), and Sightsavers International. My work has spanned over 15 countries — including Benin, Chad, DRC, Cameroon, Ethiopia, Guinea-Bissau, Malawi, Kenya, Tanzania, Nigeria, Uganda, Zambia, and Zimbabwe — where I have successfully led the design, implementation, and scale-up of impactful programmes focused on neglected tropical diseases, trachoma elimination, and neonatal mortality reduction.

Recognized as a systems thinker, I bring deep expertise in strategic leadership, programme design and execution, resource mobilization, and high-level stakeholder engagement. I have revitalized cross-functional global teams, pioneered innovative transition planning models now adopted internationally, and consistently delivered results ahead of schedule and within budget.

With extensive experience in consultancy, technical advisory, donor engagement, governance, and global representation at high-level fora, I specialize in delivering integrated solutions that strengthen national health systems, mobilize key stakeholders, and accelerate progress toward ambitious global health and development goals

EDUCATION AND PROFESSIONAL COURSES

- **Master of Public Health (Management of Health Systems)** - *University of Liverpool, UK;* September 2010 to December 2013
- **Master of Science, Management & Organizational Development** - *United States International University-Africa*; January 2004 to October 2005
- **Bachelor of Education** - *Kenyatta University*; May 1987 to August 1990

Professional Courses and Training
Mentors Summit themed: Shaping Long term well-being - Strathmore University; September 2025
Advanced Course in Diagnostics (ACDx), the Mérieux Foundation and the London School of Hygiene and Tropical Medicine, Annecy, France, September 2024
Executive Diploma in Professional Coaching (International Coaching Federation – ICF accredited), The Coaching Hub/ICF, Nairobi, Kenya, December 2023
Women Directors in Leadership, Strathmore University Business School, Nairobi, Kenya, March – December 2022

KEY SKILLS

- **Programme Design and Implementation** – Vast experience leading the design, launch, and scale-up of national and multi-country disease elimination programmes, consistently aligning with WHO and global standards.
- **Strategic Leadership and Oversight** – Skilled in developing and executing multi-year strategies, including FIND's 5-Year NTD strategic Plan and NEST360 Phase 2, while providing oversight to diverse, multidisciplinary teams across regions.
- **Technical Expertise in NTDs & Eye Health** – Experienced in advising Ministries of Health in 15+ countries on neglected tropical disease including trachoma, visceral leishmaniasis, and Human African Trypanosomiasis (sleeping sickness) and other NTDs, ensuring technical rigor and global compliance.
- **Capacity Building and Training** – Demonstrated ability to design and deliver technical trainings in English and French, mentoring Ministry of Health leadership and implementing partners to to strengthen in-country capacity.
- **Stakeholder Engagement and Partnership Management** – Skilled in building and maintaining partnerships with governments, NGOs, WHO, universities, researchers and donors to align programmes with global health priorities.
- **Monitoring and Evaluation**– Experienced in establishing robust M&E systems, leading survey data workshops, and embedding quarterly "data-for-action" reviews to drive adaptive management.
- **Resource Mobilization and Donor Engagement Expertise** – Vast experience in securing funding pipelines, developing successful multi-country proposals, and ensuring donor compliance through strong financial and operational oversight.

- **Operational and Financial Management** – Skilled in overseeing large budgets, managing financial risk, and delivering programmes efficiently, including projects completed ahead of schedule and under budget.
- **Global Health Policy & Advocacy Leadership** – Proven ability to represent organizations at high-level fora, influence adoption of global guidelines, and advocate for sustainable integration of elimination programmes.
- **Workshop Facilitation and Knowledge Sharing** – Vast experience convening and facilitating technical workshops at national and global levels, advancing best practices in diagnostics, TT elimination, and NTD strategies.

BOARD EXPERIENCE

Global Health Expertise
I am a strategic global health leader with over 20 years of experience designing and managing health programs in low-resource settings. My passion lies in connecting diverse stakeholders—people, institutions, and ideas—to address complex health challenges and drive sustainable impact. I bring deep expertise in program implementation, systems strengthening, and building collaborative partnerships across Africa, Asia, and Latin America.

Governance and Board Leadership
- **Advisor, Unlimit Health Board of Trustees (since May 2025):** Providing strategic guidance to advance equitable health solutions globally.
- **Executive Board Member, Swiss Alliance Against Neglected Tropical Diseases (2023–2024):** Contributed to shaping international NTD strategies.
- **Chair, Steering Committee for Human African Trypanosomiasis Program (2023–2024):** Oversaw a multi-country initiative spanning ten nations while serving as Director of Neglected Tropical Diseases at FIND.
- **Graduate, Women Directors in Leadership Program (2022):** Completed a one-year governance and leadership training at Strathmore Business School, Kenya, with an advanced module at Cranfield School of Management, UK, equipping me to contribute effectively to board governance.
- **Board Member, African Leadership Academy Parents Association, Kenya Chapter (2018–2020):** Supported institutional governance and parent engagement for a leading pan-African educational institution.
- **Setting up Consultant, Health Research Capacity NGO (Kenya):** Established governance structures—including Advisory Board, Board of Management, Scientific Advisory Committee, and Secretariat—while serving as Project Coordinator at IDRC, strengthening national health research capacity.

PROFESSIONAL WORK EXPERIENCE

Project Consultant, CBM – Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC); June 2025 to date
*The Ministry of Health, with CBM support, is implementing a **pilot project for the elimination of trachoma**, focusing on trachomatous trichiasis (TT) – a leading cause of preventable blindness. I am currently leading this acceleration process to ensure timely delivery and quality outcomes.*

As Project Consultant, I provide strategic, operational, and technical leadership for the fast-tracked initiation of a trachomatous trichiasis (TT) elimination pilot program in the DRC. I lead strengthening of local capacity, and ensuring that implementation is aligned with global standards to set the foundation for sustainable TT elimination.

- Driving Project Launch, I lead the rapid rollout of TT surgical services across designated provinces and ensuring the achievement of early surgical outputs within project timelines.
- Providing Technical and Operational Leadership, I oversee the implementation frameworks, operational workplans, and reporting mechanisms that comply with WHO and ICTC guidelines.
- Engaging with the Ministry of Health, district health teams, surgical staff, and international partners to harmonize activities and maintain strong communication channels.
- Conducting training, mentoring, and supportive supervision for implementers to build long-term capacity for quality service delivery.
- Trouble shooting and resolving challenges in implementation including patient mobilization, service delivery, to sustain smooth project operations.
- Establishing systems that support progress toward trachoma elimination.
- Supporting the Ministry of Health in positioning TT elimination as a national health priority and engaging with regional and global trachoma elimination networks.

Notable Achievements
- Successfully led the fast-tracked implementation of CBM's TT surgery pilot project in Tanganyika province, DRC, by coordinating multi-stakeholder efforts, aligning operations with WHO and ICTC guidelines, and addressing logistical and capacity bottlenecks launching ahead of the August 2025 deadline and positioning the programme for scalable impact in eliminating trachoma as a public health problem.

- Co-Facilitator, Preferred Practices Training on TT Elimination – Tanganyika District, DRC (June 2025): Co-facilitating training of surgical teams and program implementers on WHO-approved preferred practices for TT elimination.
- Co-Facilitator, Trachoma Elimination Planning for the Democratic Republic of Congo 2025-2030, Kinshasa (November 2025).

Director, Neglected Tropical Diseases (NTD) Programme, Sub-Saharan Africa, South East Asia, and Latin America – The Foundation for Innovative New Diagnostics (FIND) | September 2023 to December 2024

The Foundation for Innovative New Diagnostics (FIND) is a global non-profit organization driving equitable access to reliable diagnostics worldwide. FIND's NTD programme was designed to support the WHO NTD 2021–2030 Roadmap by developing, validating, and deploying context-specific diagnostics for seven priority diseases. The programme integrates clinical trials, field evaluations, specimen banking, and market intelligence to close diagnostic gaps, strengthen local manufacturing, and enable countries to achieve their NTD elimination targets.

As Director of the NTD Programme, I provided strategic and operational leadership for a global portfolio of projects across Sub-Saharan Africa, South East Asia, and Latin America.

Strategic Leadership and Programme Oversight

- Provided strategic direction and leadership for the global NTD programme, ensuring alignment with FIND's organizational strategy and the WHO NTD roadmap.
- Oversaw programme delivery across multiple geographies, with accountability for quality, efficiency, and impact.
- Initiated and led the development of the 5-Year NTD Strategic Plan (2024–2030), aligning draft frameworks with FIND's global vision, funding priorities, and country-specific needs.
- Supervised and mentored a multidisciplinary NTD team comprising scientists, project managers, and consultants.

Programme and Project Management

- Managed a diverse portfolio of projects spanning clinical trials, field evaluations, test and treat strategies, and diagnostic pipeline development, ensuring timely delivery and compliance with global standards.
- Coordinated cross-functional collaboration with the Clinical Trials Unit, Legal, Business Intelligence, Market Intelligence, Finance, and Project Management teams to streamline operations.

Financial Oversight and Risk Management

- Served as budget holder for the NTD programme with responsibility for financial oversight, budget planning, reporting, and compliance.
- Led financial risk management processes to ensure programme sustainability and donor accountability.
- Partnered with the project management and finance teams to manage grant disbursements, ensure compliance with donor requirements, and optimize resource allocation.

Partnership Development and Resource Mobilization

- Drove resource mobilization initiatives, including proposal development and engagement with donors to expand funding pipelines.
- Led business development and growth activities to secure support for pipeline projects.
- Built partnerships with governments, NGOs, research institutions, and private sector actors to advance diagnostic innovation and scale-up.

Stakeholder Engagement and Advocacy

- Represented FIND at high-level political and policy forums, advocating for diagnostic access and funding to close critical gaps in NTD programming.

Strategy and Planning

- Developed and implemented annual and multi-year strategies, budgets, and staffing structures to optimize programme delivery.
- Established performance metrics and monitoring mechanisms to track progress against programme goals and global elimination targets.

Workshops, Reviews & Global Representation

- **Workshop Convener & Lead Facilitator – NNN Annual Meeting, Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia (October 2024):** Convened and facilitated a global workshop on *Diagnostics for NTDs*, sharing lessons from Schistosomiasis, Sleeping Sickness, Visceral Leishmaniasis, and Chagas Disease to advance best practices in diagnostic innovation and scale-up.
- **Lead Facilitator – Visceral Leishmaniasis Programme Review, Nairobi, Kenya (February 2024):** Led a high-level programme review meeting for Kenya's national visceral leishmaniasis elimination programme, facilitating stakeholder consultations, reviewing programmatic strategies, and strengthening country-level implementation pathways.

Notable Achievements

- Successfully revitalized a global technical team that had lacked leadership for two years, strengthening cohesion and accountability, and leading the co-creation of a new five-year programme strategy.

- Successfully initiated transition planning for the Human African Trypanosomiasis elimination programme, co-facilitating Uganda's inaugural workshop in 2024 and establishing a model now guiding other endemic countries.

International Programs Director, Blantyre, Malawi & Nairobi, Kenya – Rice University, Institute of Global Health Technologies (IGH-T); June 2021 to May 2023

Rice University's Institute of Global Health Technologies leads the Newborn Essential Solutions & Technologies (NEST360) initiative, a global research and implementation program focused on reducing neonatal mortality. The NEST360 programme aimed to halve neonatal deaths in participating countries through the deployment of innovative technologies, hands-on education, and data-driven implementation.

As International Programs Director, I provided strategic leadership and oversight for the implementation of the NEST360 international partnership across Malawi, Kenya, Tanzania, and Nigeria. My role centered on coordinating 17 global alliance members, guiding country level implementation, , strengthening partnerships and ensuring timely delivery of activities to reduce neonatal mortality in African hospitals.

Strategic Leadership and Programme Oversight

- Led the international NEST360 programme, ensuring alignment of activities with the overall goal of reducing neonatal mortality.
- Provided oversight and guidance to Rice 360° country directors and NEST360 liaisons to ensure delivery of all programme activities within set timelines and donor commitments.
- Coordinated the efforts of 17 international alliance partners, fostering collaboration and accountability across diverse institutions.
- Contributed to the development of Phase 2 country-level proposals, which were successfully funded in 2024, ensuring programme continuity and scale-up.

Programme Implementation

- Directed in-country implementation across Malawi, Kenya, Tanzania, and Nigeria, supporting hospitals to adopt and scale innovative neonatal technologies.
- Successfully introduced quarterly review meetings that served as "data for action" sessions, enabling continuous learning, adaptation, and performance improvement.
- Supported country governments and partners in integrating new diagnostics into national elimination strategies.
- Supported the integration of evidence-based approaches and real-time data tracking to strengthen neonatal care delivery systems.

Partnership Development and Coordination

- Served as the primary liaison among 17 global alliance partners, ensuring coordination, smooth collaboration, shared accountability, and knowledge exchange.
- Strengthened partnerships with ministries of health, hospitals, universities, and donors to embed NEST360 technologies into national health systems.
- Provided strategic guidance to ensure that in-country partners were aligned with global programme objectives and country-specific health priorities.

Capacity Strengthening

- Supported hands-on training and mentorship programmes for healthcare workers, biomedical engineers, and clinicians to increase neonatal care capacity ensuring long-term sustainability of neonatal education and skills transfer.

Notable Achievements

- Successfully established quarterly review meetings in Malawi, Kenya, Tanzania, and Nigeria, embedding a culture of evidence-based decision-making and significantly improving programme monitoring and evaluation.
- Revamped leadership structures by recruiting and positioning high-performing teams in countries with capacity gaps, strengthening in-country management and ensuring accountable, consistent programme delivery.
- Successfully led targeted leadership upskilling initiatives cascaded to country and thematic teams, aligning all levels with the project's strategic vision and directly contributing to the successful design and funding of the programme's second phase.

Technical Advisor – Sightsavers International; January 2017 to June 2021

Sightsavers International is a global development organization working to eliminate avoidable blindness, promote eye health, and strengthen national health systems.

As Technical Advisor, I provided technical and programmatic leadership across a $300M global trachoma elimination portfolio, ensuring national programmes had the tools, strategies, and capacity to scale up quality interventions. I worked as part of the Global Technical Advisory Team, supporting Ministries of Health and implementing partners across Anglophone and Francophone Africa.

Technical and Strategic Advisory

- Provided technical expertise to Ministries of Health in 11+ countries, guiding national trachoma elimination programmes on policy, planning, and prioritization of interventions.

- Advised governments and partners on aligning national strategies with WHO preferred practices and the International Coalition for Trachoma Control (ICTC) guidelines.
- Led country-level programme design, including planning, budgeting, and operational set-up for new elimination programmes in both Anglophone and Francophone Africa.

Capacity Strengthening and Training

- Designed and delivered technical trainings for senior government officials, health workers, and INGO staff in English and French, strengthening in-country technical capacity.
- Conducted capacity assessments of sub-grantees and partners to evaluate readiness for programme delivery, and developed tailored support plans.
- Supported frontline programme implementation by translating global guidance into practical, community-level approaches that accelerated scale-up.

Programme Quality, Monitoring and Evidence Use

- Led multi-country workshops with Ministries of Health to interpret trachoma prevalence survey data and apply findings to programme re-design and reprogramming.
- Oversaw monitoring, evaluation, learning, and reporting processes, ensuring data-driven decision-making and adaptive management of programmes.
- Promoted uptake of evidence-based approaches, enabling countries to demonstrate progress toward elimination and secure continued donor funding.

Advocacy, Representation and Partnerships

- Represented Sightsavers and its global consortia at international policy and technical fora, presenting cutting-edge implementation research and country lessons.
- Engaged senior political leaders and health officials to advocate for prioritization of trachoma elimination within broader health agendas.
- Strengthened regional and global collaborations by contributing evidence from field programmes to inform international trachoma elimination strategies.

Notable Achievements

- As part of a 12-member Global Technical Advisory Team, led the design and implementation of trachoma elimination programmes in Beninand other countries, ensuring alignment with WHO and ICTC guidelines; contributing directly to Benin's successful validation of trachoma elimination as a public health problem in 2023.
- In Malawi, spearheaded the integration of the national trachoma programme into the routine eye health system—establishing a sustainability model that informed the development and adoption of ICTC's global transition planning guidelines, now recognized as best practice for post-elimination transition planningglobally.
- Provided high-level technical and programmatic guidance to national programmes in 11 additional countries including Cameroon, Chad, Ethiopia, Guinea-Bissau, Nigeria, Tanzania, Uganda, Zambia, and Zimbabwe strengthening programme design and implementation, with many now on track to achieve elimination ahead of the WHO 2030 roadmap target.

Regional Trachoma Programme Coordinator, Africa – CBM International; June 2014 to December 2016

CBM is an international development organization committed to improving the quality of life of people with disabilities in the world's poorest communities.

As Regional Trachoma Programme Coordinator, I provided technical and programmatic leadership for CBM's trachoma elimination portfolio in Africa, covering Chad, Kenya, Uganda, Malawi, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and South Sudan.

Regional Leadership and Programme Oversight

- Oversaw the planning, budgeting, and delivery of CBM-supported trachoma elimination programmes across four countries in sub-Saharan Africa.
- Provided technical and programmatic leadership to CBM country offices to ensure programmes were designed and implemented in alignment with WHO and ICTC preferred practices.
- Supported governments in establishing national trachoma elimination programmes, strengthening country ownership and alignment with global targets.

Technical Assistance and Capacity Strengthening

- Delivered technical trainings in English and French for Ministries of Health and partner INGO staff on trachoma elimination strategies and global guidelines.
- Provided high-level technical assistance to senior Ministry of Health officials, including guidance on strategic prioritization of elimination activities.
- Conducted capacity assessments of sub-grantees and local partners to ensure readiness for programme delivery and strengthened implementation capacity.

Programme Monitoring and Evaluation

- Led multi-country data interpretation workshops with Ministries of Health, guiding reprogramming and adaptive management based on evidence.

- Supported community-level interventions by translating technical guidelines into practical, field-level approaches that enabled scale-up of high-quality programmes.
- Oversaw monitoring, evaluation, learning, and reporting processes, ensuring accountability and evidence-based programme improvements.

Representation and Advocacy

- Represented CBM's trachoma programme at international fora and policy platforms, presenting implementation research and lessons learned.
- Strengthened regional and global partnerships by contributing to knowledge-sharing platforms and advocating for sustained investment in trachoma elimination.

Notable Achievements

- As Regional Coordinator at CBM, provided technical and programmatic leadership to trachoma elimination programmes across endemic countries.
- In Uganda, where no CBM office existed, successfully established a partner-led project team that met targets ahead of schedule and under budget.

OTHER PAST EXPERIENCES

Program Officer, Grants - Consortium for National Health Research (CNHR)
Programme Coordinator/Administrator - International Development Research Centre (IDRC) Canada
Research Administrator - Kenya Institute for Public Policy Research & Analysis (KIPPRA)
Programme Administrator - African Economic Research Consortium (AERC)

REFEREES

PROVIDED UPON REQUEST